



An Automatic Document Feeder lets you feed a stack of pages for scanning without having to manually place each page in the scanner

coming for a SCSI scanner is its immobility from one machine to another, as it requires the PC to have a SCSI adapter.

Colour depth: As a rule, if you plan on getting a scanner for slides, negatives or transparencies, you need at least 30-bit colour depth, though 36-bit would be preferable. But if you intend to scan high resolution photographs then nothing

less than 48-bit for colour and 16-bit for greyscale should do. Also make sure that the scanner supports upwards of 1200x1200 dpi resolutions.

Most of the scanners in the budget segment offered 48-bit colour depth. The exceptions were the Microtek ScanMaker 3730, Canon CanoScan D646U and CanoScan N640P (42-bit each) and the Agfa SnapScan 310P (30-bit). In the mid range section, all the scanners offered 36-bit or more colour depth, except the Mustek 1200ED, which offered a paltry colour depth of 30-bit. Microtek ScanMaker X12USL offered a bit depth of 42 bits, while the others in the high-end segment had a colour depth of 48 bits.

Ease of use: Features like Scan-to-Web, Fax, Email, Print and Copy allow even novice users to scan images without difficulty, as details regarding resolution and colour depth are handled by the TWAIN driver. For example, if you need a scanned image to be sent across to your sister in the US, you just press the Scan-to-Web button and the scanner scans at the resolution best suited for transferring it across the Net.

We found such features missing in many of the budget scanners. For example, the Agfa SnapScan 310P, the BenQ SW2 3300U and SW2 5000E, the Canon series and the Umax AstraSlim had no such buttons on them. The best of the lot here were the Microtek ScanMaker 3800 and the Mustek BearPaw 1200CU, which had all of these buttons.

In the mid range segment, the BenQ ScanPrisa 640BT and the Umax scanners had three buttons on their panel. No other manufacturer in this segment provided such easy-to-use buttons on their front panel.

Both HP scanners were clearly a step above the rest in the high-end category. The HP scanners had the four standard buttons for Copy, Email, Fax and Print plus you can also adjust brightness and contrast on the scanner.

Miscellaneous features and bundled accessories: Transparency adapters for scanning films and transparencies add greater functionality but also add to the cost of the scanner. Built-in transparency adapters were only available in three of the 23 scanners tested and that too only in the mid and high-end segment. In the mid range, the BenQ ScanPrisa 640BT was the only one with a bundled transparency adapter with support for 35 mm films, while the Umax Astra 4400 and Microtek X6EL had optional device connectors. Among the high-end scanners, Epson Perfection 1650 Photo had integrated transparency



With a Transparency Adapter you can scan negatives, slides, and transparencies

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